

Once you have downloaded and installed the software, you will be prompted to log in, or create a new account. You just need to fill up a small form by choosing your account name, password, e-mail ID, and country. Simple, fast, and hassle free; of course, you also need to enter the network settings under **Tools > Options** before you can connect. After you connect, you will be prompted to make a test call to test your headset and microphone. If you hear the automated voice and make a test call, your equipment is working fine. Otherwise you might need to install newer hardware, or install the latest patches for your older hardware.

Once these preliminaries are done, click on the **Contacts** tab and use the **Add** button to add contacts. Enter the Skype name of your contact and click on **Search**. You can also search by e-mail ID or name, or add a phone number for making calls to ordinary phones. You can also send SMSes to other phones. This phone number can



Adding contacts in Skype

be anything—local, national, international; landline or mobile. The calls are not free, though they are very cheap, especially international calls. For example, calls to the US cost around Rs 1.15 per minute. Credits can be purchased in packages of 10 (Rs 570) using either PayPal or your credit card. This feature is called **SkypeOut**.

Another feature is **SkypeIn**, where you can make a call to a computer from your phone. SkypeIn is available for numbers in countries including Australia, the UK, the US, and France. The SkypeIn system works this way: suppose a user from the UK wants to talk to a Skype subscriber in the US. That subscriber will take a UK telephone number as a SkypeIn number, and the UK caller will need to pay local rates for calls made to the US from ordinary phones. SkypeIn is not available for Indian numbers.

Videoconferencing works very well in Skype. It is currently available for Windows, Mac, and Linux. For this, you need a Skype-supported webcam. In the latest version (on Windows), Skype supports high-quality video with features like full-screen viewing and screen-